

In a non-leap year, Parshas Emor coincides with the fourth chapter of Tractate Avot. As there are no coincidences in Jewish life, what is the connection between them? Often, there is a root word or concept that appears more frequently in a particular Parsha than others. In Emor we find the root word Chilul appears many times in reference to the Kohanim as well as to the sacrifices we are obligated to bring to the Temple where the Priests perform the service on our behalf. The priest must make sure not to be Mchalel, desecrate himself, for example he is enjoined from marrying women that would be permissible to the rest of the Jewish community. The people are obligated to sanctify him because he was selected to offer sacrifices on their behalf. The high priest has even more restrictions when it comes to Chilul Kehuna. He must always remain in the Temple vicinity lest he be Mchalel his Kehuna Gedolah. Where a regular priest may defile himself in attending to the funeral of his 7 direct relatives, the Kohen Gadol may not attend any funeral, even for his parents. I would like to explore the significance of the word Chilul as well as the underlying idea it conveys.

We usually interpret the word L'Chalel as to desecrate. For example, we refer to Chilul Shabbat or Chilul Hashem as desecrating the Sabbath or Kvayachol the name of Gd. We also find the concept of Chilul when we want to redeem an item that has Hekdesh sanctity associated with it. We transfer the sanctity of the object to something else, and we can use the original item for our own purposes. The classic example is fruits of Maaser Shayni, the tithe we are obligated to bring to Jerusalem in years 1,2,4,5 of the 7-year Shmita cycle. If we have an abundant harvest and cannot transport all of it to Jerusalem, we can redeem the fruits for money which we then spend in Jerusalem. The Chilul removes the sanctity of the object and renders it Chol or mundane, usable outside Jerusalem. Indeed, the prohibitions against Chilul Shabbat and Chilul Hashem derive from our obligation to treat Hashem and the Sabbath with special reverence. Doing anything that negates or diminishes that reverence or renders them mundane, Chol, is considered a grave sin, punishable by death under certain conditions.

Interestingly, we also find the word Kadosh, sanctity, appearing throughout the Parsha. Kedusha and Chilul are opposites. They cannot co-exist in the same object. Nor can they co-exist in the same person. If he is deserving, we exalt and honor the priest, V'Kidashto. If he desecrates the people's trust and his position, he causes Chilul Kehuna, desecration of the Priesthood, which ultimately leads to Chilul Hashem, desecration of Gd's name. The priest is the link between the people and Gd. If he acts in a way that demonstrates a mundane attitude towards Gd by trivializing his Kehuna, he cannot perform his appointed

tasks. If Gd's selected representatives act in a way that impugns the priesthood, ultimately it reflects poorly on Gd as well. The priest will forfeit any respect the people had for him. An individual cannot be self-contradictory, sanctified and revered while acting like the rest of society. A prince does not behave as a commoner. People will perceive him by his actions, for good or bad.

However, there is more to the priest than the physical service performed in the Temple. The Torah and prophets tell us that the priests also served as the judges and teachers. They needed to act in a transparent way that was beyond reproach. For if they themselves were immoral or did not respect the Torah laws, whether between Man and Gd or Man and Man, the result would be not only a lack of respect and appreciation of the priests themselves, but it would reflect poorly on the Torah and Gd. The ultimate desecration occurs if a Priest or a judge or teacher twists the law and acts improperly. Immoral leaders set a slippery slope the rest of society will fall on.

Why do the actions of the Priests, judges and teachers reflect so heavily on the honor of Gd, Kedushat Hashem? Why are they so special? In Parshat Ki Teitze we are told:

דברים כא:כג

וְכִי־יִהְיֶה בְּאִישׁ תֹּטָא מִשְׁפָּט־מִנֹּת וְהוֹמַת וְתִלִּית אֹתוֹ עַל־עֵץ: לֹא־תִלִּין נִבְלָתוֹ עַל־הָעֵץ כִּי־קָבֹר תִּקְבְּרֻנּוּ בַּיּוֹם הַהוּא כִּי־קָלַת אֱלֹהִים תִּלְוִי וְלֹא תִטְמָא אֶת־אֲדָמָתְךָ אֲשֶׁר יְהוָה אֱלֹהֶיךָ נָתַן לְךָ נִחְלָה:

רש"י

כי קללת אלהים תלוי. ולזולו של מלך הוא, שאדם עשוי בדמות דיוקנו, וישראל הם בניו; משל לשני אחים תאומים שהיו דומים זה לזה, אחד נעשה מלך ואחד נתפס ללסטיות ונתלה, כל הרוצה אותו אומר המלך תלוי.

We are told in the Book of Genesis that man was created in the image of Gd:

בראשית א:כז

וַיִּבְרָא אֱלֹהִים אֶת־הָאָדָם בְּצַלְמוֹ בְּצֶלֶם אֱלֹהִים בָּרָא אֹתוֹ זָכָר וּנְקֵבָה בָּרָא אֹתָם:

בראשית ט:

שֹׁפֵךְ דָּם הָאָדָם בְּאָדָם דָּמוֹ יִשְׁפָּךְ כִּי בְצֶלֶם אֱלֹהִים עָשָׂה אֶת־הָאָדָם:

When people see a criminal, who bears a strong resemblance to his Creator, swinging from a tree by a noose around his neck, they may think that it is the Creator, Kvayachol, hanging, and not his look-alike relative. When man sins, he reflects poorly on Gd, his Creator. King

David describes how man can reach near Godly heights, reflective of his Creator. He also can descend to the lowest depths, considered lower than the mosquito and as irrelevant as dust and ashes:

תהילים ה-ז

מִה־אֲנוֹשׁ כִּי־תִזְכָּרְנוּ וּבִן־אָדָם כִּי תִפְקְדֶנּוּ: וּתְחַסְּרֶהוּ מִעַט מַאֲלָהִים וְכְבוֹד וְהִדָּר תַּעֲטֶרְהוּ: תִּמְשִׁילֶהוּ בְּמַעַשֵׁי יָדָיו כָּל־שֵׂתָהּ תַּחֲתִירְגְּלֶיוּ:

When man acts properly, and sanctifies Gd's name, he reflects well on his Creator, Who is happy that man was created in His image. However, if he desecrates Gd's name by acting immorally, he is considered useless, like the dust and ashes of the earth.

The Talmud tells us:

נדה לא:א

תָּנוּ רַבֵּנָן: **שְׁלֹשָׁה שוֹתֵפִין יֵשׁ בָּאָדָם** — הַקָּדוֹשׁ בְּרוּךְ הוּא, וְאָבִיו, וְאִמּוֹ.

There are 3 partners in creating a human being: father, mother and Gd. When an individual sins, his actions reflect on his parents and Gd. When he is exposed for all to see in his sinful state, observers can easily confuse him with his Creator, in whose image he was created. When the sinful individual is a Priest, judge, teacher, rabbi, community leader, the associated Chilul Hashem is magnified even more. Such individuals must always be mindful of their actions. The slightest error can have terrible consequences.

The Torah does not tell us when Rebecca died. We have a hint as to her passing when the Torah tells us about the death of Rebecca's nursemaid, Devorah. Rashi quotes the Midrash that Gd did not want to mention her passing in the Torah, lest people curse the womb that brought Esau into the world. Esau's immoral and wicked life reflected on his mother. (See Rashi Genesis 35:8 ד"ה תחת האלון)

The Talmud derives the obligation to sanctify the name of Hashem when it is called for from the verse:

ויקרא כב:לב

וְלֹא תִחַלְלוּ אֶת־שֵׁם קֹדֶשׁי וְנִקְדַּשְׁתִּי בְּתוֹךְ בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל אֲנִי יְהוָה מְקַדְּשְׁכֶם:

Desecration and sanctification are two sides of a coin. They cannot coexist. Where Kiddush Hashem is the highest level a Jew can attain by sacrificing his life for Gd when called upon, the stain and punishment associated with Chilul Hashem is the gravest. Maimonides says that one who seeks to atone for a sin associated with Chilul Hashem must undergo various punishments, including afflictions and ultimately death to remove the sin:

רמב"ם הלכות תשובה א:ד

אָבֵל הַמְּחַלֵּל אֶת הַשֵּׁם אַף עַל פִּי שֶׁעָשָׂה תְּשׁוּבָה וְהִגִּיעַ יוֹם הַכַּפּוּרִים וְהָיָא עוֹמֵד בְּתַשׁוּבָתוֹ וּבָאוּ עָלָיו יְסוּרִין אֵינּוּ מִתְּכַפֵּר לוֹ כְּפָרָה גְּמוּלָה עַד שְׁיָמוּת. אֲלֵא תְּשׁוּבָה יוֹם הַכַּפּוּרִים וְיְסוּרִין שֶׁלֹּשְׁתֵּן תּוֹלִין וּמִיָּתָה מְכַפֵּרֶת שְׁנָאָמַר (ישעיה כב יד) "וְנִגְלָה בְּאָזְנִי ה' צְבָאוֹת" וְגו' (ישעיה כב יד) "אִם יִכְפֹּר הָעֶזְרֹן הִנֵּה לָכֶם עַד תִּמָּתוּן":

Tractate Avot focuses on the interpersonal laws and how people, especially rabbis and judges should treat their fellow human beings. Chazal were very mindful that people in positions of Torah and community responsibility act properly, avoiding even the hint of impropriety. The Talmud tells us (Yuma 86a) that Rav would not buy meat from a butcher on credit, lest people think he was stealing, causing a Chilul Hashem. Clearly Rav would never act in this way, but even the possibility of someone misconstruing his actions and causing a desecration of Gd's name because of his important position, was enough to make Rav sensitive to the possibility.

The fourth chapter in Avot focuses on the same ideas: Desecration and Sanctification of the name of Gd, by acting appropriately in interpersonal matters, בין אדם לחברו, or between man and Gd, בין אדם למקום. For example:

אבות ד:א

אֵיזָהוּ מְכַבֵּד, הַמְּכַבֵּד אֶת הַבְּרִיּוֹת, שְׁנָאָמַר (שמואל א ב) כִּי מְכַבְּדִי אֶכְבֵּד וּבְזִי יִקְלוּ:

אבות ד:ב

רַבִּי לִוִּיטָס אִישׁ יִבְנֶה אוֹמֶר, מֵאֵד מֵאֵד הָיָא שְׁפַל רוּחַ, שֶׁתְּקַנֵּת אֲנוּשׁ רַמָּה. רַבִּי יוֹחָנָן בֶּן בְּרוּקָא אוֹמֶר, כָּל הַמְּחַלֵּל שֵׁם שְׁמַיִם בִּסְתֵּר, נִכְרַעֵין מִמֶּנּוּ בְּגָלוּי. אֶחָד שׁוֹגֵג וְאֶחָד מְזִיד בְּחִלּוּל הַשֵּׁם:

אבות ד:ז

רַבִּי יוֹסִי אוֹמֶר, כָּל הַמְּכַבֵּד אֶת הַתּוֹרָה, גּוֹפֹחַ מְכַבֵּד עַל הַבְּרִיּוֹת. וְכָל הַמְּחַלֵּל אֶת הַתּוֹרָה, גּוֹפֹחַ מְחַלֵּל עַל הַבְּרִיּוֹת:

אבות ג:יב

רַבִּי אֱלֵעָזָר בֶּן שְׁמוּעַ אוֹמֶר, יְהִי כְבוֹד תַּלְמִידָךְ חָבִיב עָלֶיךָ כְּשֶׁלָּךְ, וּכְבוֹד חֲבֵרְךָ כְּמוֹרָא רַבָּה, וּמוֹרָא רַבָּה כְּמוֹרָא שְׁמַיִם:

Chazal recognized that Kavod HaBriyot, respect for other people and Gd's creation, is another indicator of desecration or sanctification of Gd's name. If a scholar, teacher, judge treats other people fairly and with dignity, people will praise him as well as Gd and His Torah that taught him such exemplary character traits, resulting in a true sanctification of Gd's name. If one acts improperly and immorally, people will reject the Teacher and Teachings, Hashem and His Torah, causing a terrible desecration of Gd's name.

אבות ג'יד

הוא הנה אומר, **תביב אדם שונברא בצלם**. חכה יתרה נודעת לו **שונברא בצלם**, שנאמר כי בצלם אלהים עשה את **האדם**.

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